Inverted Pyramid Checklist

When you write an inverted pyramid news story, use the following checklist to make sure that you have done it correctly.

From http://www.jprof.com/writing/invertedpyramidchecklist.html

Information should be presented in descending order of importance.

Leads

- ☐ One sentence
- ☐ 30-35 words maximum
- ☐ Lead tells the most important information in the story and gives specific facts

Second paragraph

- ☐ Expand or develop some idea introduced in the lead
- ☐ Should not drop the story into a chronological narrative

Attribution

- ☐ All major information should be attributed unless it is commonly known or unless the information itself strongly implies the source.
- ☐ Don't dump a string of direct quotations on the reader.
- ☐ Direct quotations should be no more than two sentences long.
- ☐ Direct quotations and their attribution should be punctuated properly. Here's an example:

  "John did not go with her," he said.

- ☐ Elements of a direct quotation should be in the proper sequence, as in the example above: direct quote, speaker, verb.

AP style

- ☐ Always. Check numbers, dates, locations, titles, etc.

Check the following

- ☐ Pronoun-antecedent agreement
- ☐ It, its, it's

  "it is . . .", "there is . . .", "there are . . ." structures; avoid these. They are passive and vague.

- ☐ Use the past tense, not the present.
- ☐ Comma splice or run-on sentence, such as

  He picked up the ball, he ran down the field.
  Sally does not know where he is he is not here.
  These are grammatically incorrect.

- ☐ Plurals -- don't make them by using an "apostrophe s".

Short paragraphs

- ☐ Any paragraph more than three sentences is definitely too long
- ☐ Any paragraph that is three sentences is probably too long.

Wordiness

- ☐ Have you checked for too much verbiage, redundancies, unnecessary repetitions, etc.

Name, title

- ☐ When you put the title before a name, do not separate them with commas, such as

  (WRONG): Game warden, Brad Fisher, arrested the trespassers.

- ☐ When the name comes before the title, the title should be set off by commas.

  Brad Fisher, the game warden, arrested the trespassers.

Transitions

- ☐ Use them to tie your paragraphs together. Don't jump from one subject to another in a new paragraph without giving the reader some warning.

Don't copy the wording of the information sheet.

Names

- ☐ Check them once more to make sure they are spelled correctly.